

LOOKING AHEAD TO 2024 **ARCHERY**

SPIRITED QUEST TO END MEDAL DROUGHT

Amidst the upswing in archery in the country, one wonders whether **Indian archers can finally achieve** the much-longed-for Olympic medal in Paris this year.

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Indian archery witnessed some historic moments in 2023, which may inspire the archers to push themselves in 2024 to achieve an elusive Olympic medal in Paris. The compound archers stamped their class at the elite level by securing three of the five gold medals at the World Championships in Berlin. It was a first for the country, which did not have a single world title in the sport. Seventeen-year-old Aditi Swami was the highlight, securing two world titles in women's archery: one in the team category alongside Jyothi Surekha Vennam and Parneet Kaur and another in the individual event.

Aditi's academy mate from Maharashtra, Ojas Deotale, secured the men's individual gold medal as India swept the individual compound titles in the World Championships.

Compound archers shone in the Hangzhou Asian Games by picking up seven medals, including five golds. Deotale, Abhishek Verma,

and Prathamesh Jawkar had a fantastic year in which Deotale beat World No. 1 Mike Schuessler twice and claimed a World Cup stage gold, and the trio won the team gold medal.

World champion Deotale also clinched the individual gold, beating compatriot Verma, and the mixed team title with Jyothi. The women archers also gave dazzling performances, with the seasoned Jyothi bagging three gold medals, leading the world champion trio (including Aditi and Parneet) to the team title, besides claiming the individual crown and the mixed team gold. It was disheartening to see Jyothi being ignored for the Khel Ratna award despite her magnificent showing throughout the calendar.

India's superlative performance, which was much better than the two silver medals in Bangkok in 2018, trumped its previous best of four medals in 2014 and pushed the formidable South Korea — which won 11 medals, including four gold, this time and had been ruling the archery competitions since 1982 —

to the second position in Hangzhou. Korea had a higher overall number of medals in the sport but had a lower gold medal count.

In the Asian Games, the recurve archers won medals in men's and women's team events after 13 years. It was a creditable effort because several top countries, including traditional powerhouse Korea, competed in the continental showpiece event.

The Indian archers' combined showing resulted in the best-ever return of nine medals.

After athletics and shooting, archery was the third-most medal-producing sport, and it helped India cross the milestone of 100 medals for the first time.

Italian coach Sergio Pagni's able guidance played a significant part in the Indian compound archers' superb showing, which included 12 medals in the World Cups. Meanwhile, the recurve archers also produced noticeable results, including five medals in World Cups. Even though the Indians could not qualify for the Olympics through the World Championships, they finished